

Sacred Time, Family, Ministry & Interreligious Framework

Operational frameworks that remain truthful while theology develops

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Working research for UNDECIDED

Research rule: distinguish primary witness, historical reconstruction, philosophical argument, theological interpretation, ethical safeguard, and institutional decision. Confidence may never outrun evidence.

1. Why an operational framework now

People need to know how to live together before every metaphysical question is settled. This document creates bounded practices for four sensitive domains: intimate/family life, sacred time, ministry/rites, and interreligious relationships. Each framework is deliberately reversible where theology remains open.

2. Intimate and family ethics framework

2.1 Minimum ethical floor

- Capacity and meaningful consent are required for sexual and marital decisions.
- Coercion by spiritual status, prophecy, money, employment, housing, immigration status, dependency, or threatened exclusion is incompatible with the Way.
- Adults are responsible for honesty about commitments, sexual health information material to consent, financial obligations, and dependents.
- Violence, stalking, sexual assault, child abuse, grooming, and coercive control are safeguarding/legal matters before they are pastoral reconciliation matters.
- No person gains spiritual rank by marrying, remaining celibate, having children, remaining childless, or conforming to a leader's preferred family form.

2.2 What the Assembly does not yet decide

- Sacramental status of marriage
- Same-sex marriage/blessing theology
- Divorce and remarriage doctrine
- Contraception and procreation theology
- Gender/sex metaphysics
- Plural marriage
- Mandatory celibacy for any ministry
- Interfaith/dual-tradition marriage rites

2.3 Pastoral boundary

Pastoral care may help people examine values, commitments, safety, grief, conflict, fidelity, and responsibility. It may not compel a person to marry, divorce, reconcile, reproduce, abstain from lawful adult relationships, or disclose intimate facts merely to prove loyalty. Any future marriage rite must be separately adopted.

3. Sacred-time framework

3.1 Adopt rhythm before calendar

- Daily: voluntary periods of attention/prayer consistent with v0.7.
- Weekly: at least one recurring communal gathering rhythm for prayer, study, fellowship, service, or rest; the universal required weekday remains open.
- Monthly or periodic: communal service, extended study, discernment, or Common Table as local practice develops.
- Seasonal: periods of remembrance, gratitude, self-examination, generosity, fasting/abstinence if safely chosen, and renewal may be piloted.

- Annual: Houses publish an observance calendar in advance and label inherited-tradition observances, Way-created observances, and civil/community events distinctly.

3.2 Fasting safety rule

No fasting rule may require unsafe abstinence. Children, pregnancy/breastfeeding, diabetes, eating disorders, medications, disabilities, strenuous labor, illness, older age, and other health conditions must be accommodated without spiritual penalty. Alternatives may include simplified food, media abstinence, charitable giving, silence, service, or another voluntary discipline.

3.3 Calendar non-appropriation rule

A House may learn from or respectfully observe source-tradition holy days, but it must not relabel a Jewish, Christian, Muslim, Buddhist, Hindu, Sikh, Indigenous, or other festival as if the Way originated or owned it. Participation should identify the source tradition and preserve its context.

4. Rites and ministry framework

4.1 Current authority model

- Commissioning remains the normal authorization for defined ministry functions.
- Every commission states scope, term/review date where applicable, supervision, safeguarding requirements, financial authority (if any), and explicit limits.
- Ordination is not yet used to imply ontological change, sacramental character, succession, or a permanent clerical caste.
- Rites currently approved in v0.7 remain provisional practices subject to the safeguards in this volume.

4.2 Rite truthfulness test

1. What transition, commitment, memory, or prayer is this rite expressing?
2. What factual or metaphysical claims does its language make?
3. Which claims are established, provisional, inherited from another tradition, symbolic, or merely hoped?
4. Could a vulnerable person mistake the rite for an irreversible legal, sexual, financial, or spiritual transfer of control?
5. What opt-out, accessibility, child-protection, and conscience safeguards apply?
6. Who may officiate and why does that role require authorization?

5. Interreligious framework

5.1 Disciplined hospitality

- Learn a tradition first from its primary sources, practitioners, and responsible scholarship before criticizing it.
- Distinguish "this tradition teaches X" from "all members believe X" and from "the Way judges X to be true."
- Cooperate across traditions in charity, peacebuilding, education, disaster relief, and other common goods without pretending doctrinal agreement.
- Welcome visitors and Companions who maintain relationships with other traditions; do not require family or friendship rupture.

- Never misrepresent participation in a source-tradition ritual as endorsement by that tradition or automatic incorporation into the Way.

5.2 Conversion and Companion identity

Becoming a Companion is a voluntary religious identification within the Way. It does not require denouncing one's ancestry, relatives, former community, or every belief learned elsewhere. Some prior commitments may conflict with Companion commitments; those conflicts must be examined specifically rather than resolved by blanket hostility toward the prior tradition.

5.3 Dual belonging

Formal dual religious belonging remains an open theological question. The Way should not prohibit exploration merely because it complicates identity. Conversely, it should not claim that dual belonging is always coherent when another tradition understands its initiation, covenant, creed, or law as exclusive. The appropriate posture is case-specific honesty.

6. Implementation tests for a House of Prayer

1. Can a person attend for six months without being pressured to become a Companion?
2. Can a Companion marry or decline marriage without losing ordinary standing?
3. Can a person decline fasting, a rite, a minister's counsel, or a religious interpretation without retaliation?
4. Can a Minister say "I do not know" about death, suffering, sexuality, or another religion without being considered disloyal?
5. Can a House cooperate with a synagogue, church, mosque, temple, sangha, secular charity, or public institution without pretending doctrinal agreement?
6. Can a commissioned leader be suspended or removed without a metaphysical crisis about sacred status?
7. Can the observance calendar change when practice shows that an experiment is unhelpful?

7. Decisions deferred to future volumes

- Final marriage/covenant rite and marriage theology
- A comprehensive sacred calendar and any distinctive calendar system
- Whether ordination is adopted
- Any sacramental theology of the Common Table or initiation
- Definitive teaching on afterlife or final salvation/liberation
- A formal doctrine of interreligious pluralism, inclusivism, exclusivism, or multiple belonging

Source notes

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